influential (and insightful) portrayals of the absurdity and horror of nuclear war.[12] In both, the global spread of lethally toxic radioactive fallout condemns humanity to oblivion.

Understanding the risk of thermonuclear war during the Cold War provides essential context for understanding the risk of thermonuclear war today. Most historians and commentators believe that October 1962 was the closest we came to the abyss. Since then, a vast amount of research and revelation has illuminated how close we may have been. As evidence has emerged of what happened at the military level in October 1962, there has been growing recognition of the risk of ‘inadvertent nuclear war’ when military commanders could have been close to using their nuclear weapons. More optimistically, there has also been greater understanding of the extent to which Kennedy and Khrushchev were determined to draw back from the brink.

Much evidence has come from the testimony of surviving participants, especially former US, Soviet, and Cuban officials who gathered together in conferences organised by scholars and think tanks. This technique of exploring history by combining personal testimony, documentary evidence, and robust debate, became known as ‘critical oral history’. The results helped challenge received wisdoms, and in particular, accounts from former Kennedy administration officials as well as studies by historians, journalists, and political scientists who depended on their testimony.

Other important sources of information emerged. In the US, transcripts and recordings of President Kennedy’s meetings with his senior officials were published.[13] Unbeknownst to his advisers, the President secretly recorded their discussions, including those of what became known as the Executive Committee of the National Security Committee (ExComm). These records not only provided insight into debates in the White House but enabled previously published accounts to be assessed for their veracity.

Sadly (for historians) Premier Khrushchev did not replicate President Kennedy’s duplicity and there are no recordings of the Presidium of the Central Committee of the Soviet Communist Party (as the Politburo was then called). There is speculation that Kennedy made the tapes to assist him with his memoirs. When Nikita Khrushchev wrote his memoirs a decade or